WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

FRENCH GUIANA

Americas

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Kourou / Guiana Space Centre (CSG)	Europe's spaceport; seven launches in 2025 (four Ariane 6, three Vega-C) and 10–11 expected in 2026, with space accounting for 58.2% of exports	Space services, engineering, logistics, hospitality
CSG Diamant site (NewSpace launchers)	Historic pad being redeveloped for micro- and mini-launchers; PLD Space is investing €35 million, including €13 million with local firms, and Sirius Space was selected in April 2026	Launcher services, civil engineering, industrial subcontracting
Cayenne, Matoury and Rémire-Montjoly	Capital region (Cayenne about 61,600 inhabitants) and home to Félix Éboué airport, where an €85 million modernisation began in July 2026	Public and business services, aviation, retail, construction
Dégrad des Cannes (Grand Port Maritime de la Guyane)	Main commercial port handling 961,361 tonnes and 74,594 TEU in 2025; two new cranes and €11 million of investment planned for 2026	Logistics, distribution, port services
Larivot and Sinnamary energy sites	New bioenergy capacity: the €600 million, 120 MW Larivot plant (delivery planned February 2027) and the €145 million Sinnamary biomass plant	Renewable energy, engineering, biomass supply
West: Saint-Laurent-du-Maroni and Mana	Fast-growing western hub on the Suriname border; site of the €170 million CEOG solar-hydrogen power plant and a major AFD-backed hospital	Energy, health, housing, agriculture, cross-border trade
Interior gold belt	Home to 102 of France's 123 mines; legal mining-permit applications rose to 52 in 2025 from 27 in 2024	Responsible gold mining, mining services, environmental services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Guyane Développement Innovation (GDI), the regional development agency, works with Business France and Team France Invest under a 2023–2028 partnership to attract and support investors
- Tax-free business zones (ZFANG): in French Guiana all eligible SMEs (fewer than 250 staff, turnover under €50 million) receive the enhanced 80% profit abatement, capped at €300,000 a year, regardless of sector

- National overseas incentives, including LODEOM employer social-contribution exemptions and overseas productive-investment tax aid, alongside EU cohesion funding managed with the Collectivité Territoriale de Guyane (CTG)
- CNES launch-site access for private launcher operators at the Guiana Space Centre, where a shared Diamant site with common energy and oxygen infrastructure is opening to micro- and mini-launchers
- Full French and EU legal framework: the euro is the currency, IEDOM acts as the Banque de France's local arm, and there are no capital controls or repatriation restrictions
- Public co-financing from AFD (including a €90 million facility for the CTG, a €55 million loan for the Sinnamary biomass plant and €35 million for the Lum@link submarine cable) and Banque des Territoires
- Mining titles under the French Mining Code, processed through the Prefecture, for exploration and exploitation in the legal gold sector

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

French Guiana offers investors a euro-denominated, French and EU jurisdiction on the South American continent, and its economy has returned firmly to growth. GDP rose 3.9% in volume in 2025 to €5.5 billion, after contractions in 2023 and 2024, well ahead of mainland France (0.8%), as the return of Ariane 6 and Vega-C launches lifted exports by 76.1%. Private investment grew 14.7% in value, led by the Larivot (€600 million) and Sinnamary (€145 million) bioenergy plants, and business investment credit rose 10%. Momentum has carried into 2026: in the second quarter paid hours rose 2.7% year on year, salaried employment reached 76,400 (+2.2%, with the private sector up 3.8%), and IEDOM's business-climate indicator stood at 105.2, above its long-term average for four quarters. Inflation is moderate at 1.5% in 2025 and 1.8% in June 2026. Separate FDI statistics are not published, but new private launcher investment at Kourou, an €85 million airport upgrade and the Lum@link cable due in December 2026 point to rising investor interest.

French Guiana's main structural challenge is creating private-sector jobs fast enough for a young and growing population of about 298,600, 39% of whom are under 20. Unemployment was 20.4% in mid-2026 (8.3% nationally), GDP per capita is about €18,500, and exports cover only around 13% of imports. Mitigation is substantial: all eligible SMEs receive enhanced 80% ZFANG tax relief, AFD and Banque des Territoires finance schools, health, energy and connectivity, and new bioenergy and solar-hydrogen plants are modernising the power system. Institutional change is also under discussion: elected officials are seeking greater autonomy within the French Republic, with constitutional proposals under preparation, and Jean-Paul Ferreira was elected CTG president on 26 October 2026. For investors, the opportunities lie in import substitution for a fast-growing market, NewSpace supply chains, renewable energy, responsible mining and services linked to the offshore oil expansion of neighbouring Suriname and Guyana.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Labour-market slack and skills	Unemployment rose to 20.4% in mid-2026, more than twice the national rate, although private salaried employment grew 3.8% year on year	Use ZFANG and LODEOM to lower costs and invest in local training; a young, expanding workforce supports labour-intensive projects
Concentration on space activity	Space accounts for 58.2% of exports, and the economy contracted in 2023–2024 during the transition to Ariane 6	Launch cadence is recovering to 10–11 a year and NewSpace operators are diversifying CSG demand, creating subcontracting opportunities
Small market and import dependence	Exports covered only 12.6% of imports in the second quarter of 2026, raising input and freight costs	Port investment and new cranes improve logistics; import substitution and local processing serve a population growing about 1.4% a year
Institutional evolution and political transition	Talks on greater autonomy are under way, and Jean-Paul Ferreira was elected CTG president on 26 October 2026 following the death of Gabriel Serville	Any change requires a constitutional process with a three-fifths parliamentary majority, giving a long lead time; engage both the State and the CTG
Illegal gold mining and environmental scrutiny	About 600 illegal sites operate in the interior, and mining projects attract close environmental review	Work through the Prefecture's permitting process and apply high environmental standards; high gold prices are

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
		encouraging modernisation of the legal sector
Energy-system transition	The fuel-oil plant at Dégrad des Cannes is due to close at the end of 2026, with Larivot delivery planned for February 2027; CEOG was delayed by about two years	New bioenergy, biomass and solar-hydrogen capacity is creating a cleaner, more resilient grid and opportunities for energy investors
Public-spending pressures	Public administration spending fell 6.9% and public investment 9.2% in 2025	AFD's €90 million CTG facility and EU funds sustain the infrastructure pipeline, while private investment grew 14.7%

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

French Guiana's risk profile is that of a French and EU jurisdiction: legal, currency and transfer risks are low, contracts are enforced under French law, and the euro removes exchange-rate exposure for euro-area investors. Growth rebounded to 3.9% in 2025, inflation is moderate, and business sentiment remains above its long-term average. The main considerations are structural and operational: high unemployment, reliance on space activity, a small import-dependent market, illegal gold mining in the interior and the timing of energy-system upgrades. The autonomy discussions and the election of Jean-Paul Ferreira as CTG president on 26 October 2026 are a political process within the French constitutional framework, with any statutory change requiring lengthy parliamentary approval. Investors should take local tax advice, model incentives conservatively, plan for energy and logistics lead times, and engage early with the Prefecture, the CTG and GDI, while the territory's growth, EU standards and strategic position offer a sound base for long-term investment.

MARKET ACCESS

As a French overseas department and region governed by a single Collectivité Territoriale de Guyane, French Guiana is an outermost region of the European Union and the only EU territory on the South American continent, fully within the EU single market and customs union and using the euro. Through France it is covered by WTO membership and EU trade agreements, and it shares land and river borders with Brazil (Amapá state) and Suriname, where the CTG maintains an office and regional partnerships are growing around offshore energy and the bioeconomy. Space services dominate exports (58.2% in 2025), with gold, agri-food and wood among other exports, and non-space exports rose 10.3% in 2025. The Grand Port Maritime de la Guyane has opened a border inspection post for phytosanitary and veterinary checks and is studying a coastal shipping line across the Guianas Plateau, possibly linking to Brazil. The Lum@link submarine cable to Europe, due in December 2026, and the modernised Cayenne airport will strengthen connectivity.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Préfecture de la Guyane (Prefect Antoine Poussier)	Represents the French State, overseeing state services, security, mining permits and major public projects	Primary reference point for state policy, permitting and the legal mining sector
Collectivité Territoriale de Guyane (CTG)	Single regional and departmental authority leading economic strategy, EU funds and the autonomy process; led by President Jean-Paul Ferreira, elected on 26 October 2026	Key partner for co-financing, strategic sectors and regional cooperation
Guyane Développement Innovation (GDI)	Regional development and innovation agency, partnered with Business France and active in regional networks such as the RIPA bioeconomy project	Standard first point of contact for market entry and investor facilitation
CNES / Guiana Space Centre	Operates Europe's spaceport and allocates launch sites to new private operators	Essential counterpart for space-sector and NewSpace supply-chain investment

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
IEDOM (Institut d'émission des départements d'outre-mer)	Acts as the Banque de France's arm in the overseas departments, monitoring credit, prices and the business climate	Authoritative source of economic and banking-sector intelligence
Grand Port Maritime de la Guyane	State port authority at Dégrad des Cannes, investing €11 million in 2026 under its 2024–2028 strategic plan	Counterpart for logistics, regional shipping and port-related investment
AFD (Agence française de développement)	Leading public financier for the CTG, energy, health, digital connectivity and cross-border projects	Co-financing partner for infrastructure and public-private projects

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

Guyane Développement Innovation acts as the hub for investor facilitation and innovation networks, working with Business France and Team France Invest on investor prospecting. The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of Guyane (CCIG) provides local business liaison and is a shareholder in the new Cayenne airport concession alongside Egis, Banque des Territoires and local partners. AFD and Banque des Territoires are the principal public financiers, and the CTG's office in Suriname, together with participation in events such as the Suriname Energy, Oil and Gas Summit, opens channels to the wider Guianas Plateau. Arianespace, CNES and the new private launcher operators at Kourou are useful sources of intelligence on space-sector procurement and subcontracting.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

French Guiana suits investors seeking a secure, euro-denominated EU base in South America: space and NewSpace suppliers serving the Guiana Space Centre's rising launch cadence and new private launch pads; renewable-energy, biomass and hydrogen investors supporting the shift to a cleaner power system; construction, housing, health and education specialists serving one of France's fastest-growing populations; and logistics, distribution and agri-food firms able to replace imports and use the enhanced 80% ZFANG relief available to all eligible SMEs. Responsible mining investors and service firms targeting the offshore energy boom in Suriname and Guyana can also use French Guiana as a French-law platform for regional operations.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage GDI, the CTG and the Prefecture
Open dialogue with the regional development agency, the newly elected CTG leadership and state services to identify priority sectors, sites, permits and co-financing.

STEP 2: Model ZFANG, LODEOM and investment tax aid
Take local tax advice to confirm eligibility for the enhanced 80% ZFANG abatement, social-contribution exemptions and overseas investment tax aid, and track incentive reviews.

STEP 3: Map space-sector supply-chain opportunities
Approach CNES, Arianespace and new launcher operators at the Diamant site on procurement, construction and service contracts linked to the rising launch cadence.

STEP 4: Explore AFD, Banque des Territoires and EU co-financing
Seek co-funding for energy, infrastructure, health and digital projects, building on existing programmes with the CTG and private developers.

STEP 5: Use French Guiana as a regional platform
Leverage CTG and GDI links with Suriname, Guyana and Brazil, the planned coastal shipping studies and the Lum@link cable to develop partnerships across the Guianas Plateau.